



كلية الحوسبة والمعلوماتية
COLLEGE OF COMPUTING
AND INFORMATICS

University of Sharjah
College of Computing and
Informatics
Department of Computer Engineering
Computer Engineering Program

Senior Design Project Guide

Dr. Saddaf Rubab
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1. Senior Design Project I

In this section, explanations of the important points about SDP1 are detailed.

1.1. Group Registration and Supervisor selection

Group registration has to be carried out by students. You have to look for like-minded students to work with during the SDP. It is important that you try to find students to work with otherwise you will be put in a group randomly. This will have implications on the group dynamics later on. So, students should try to find a group early on before the start of the SDP. The number of students within a group should be three students. Groups with two students might be allowed in special circumstances only.

Once you form the group, you should start to look for a supervisor. You should email and visit faculty and discuss with them potential SDP ideas. Once you settle on the supervisor, you have to fill the form and send it to the SDP coordinator.

1.2. SDP Proposal

Once you select your supervisor, you have to start looking at possible SDP ideas. The idea has to be a comprehensive idea that has implementable potential so you can produce a physical prototype at the end of your SDP.

It is also possible to work on research ideas. In this case, the work has to be advanced enough in order to produce publishable results.

Novel, practical, and useful ideas get the highest grades. So, it is worth it to spend sometime looking at example ideas from resources such as IEEE spectrum, IEEE xplore, IEEE computer magazine, etc and see what other students in other universities are doing.

Ideals in the following topics are always winners in competitions:

- Biomedical engineering
- Renewable energy
- Robotics and drones
- Community service

Your SD project should have some of the following components based on the project type and nature:

- Microcontroller, Arduino or RaspberryPi
- Sensors connected to the controller

- Camera connected to the controller to capture images or video, etc.
- Circuit built to do a specific task
- Machine learning for prediction
- Mobile application that does a certain task
- Motors of different sorts, DC etc.
- Solar panel, DC-DC converter, etc.

Once you submit your proposal, the SDP committee is going to review your proposal and send it to you with modification and improvements. If you do not hear back from the SDP committee, you can assume that there are no comments and you can start working on your project right away.

There will be a mark given to the submitted proposal by the SDP committee. A specific rubric is used to mark all proposals.

1.3. Weekly work with the supervisor

Once you get the proposal approved by the SDP committee, you should schedule a fixed weekly schedule with your supervisor. The meeting has to be face-to-face in the supervisor office. Meeting face-to-face is better for proper communication and understanding. You can meet online for exceptional situations only.

The supervisor is going to assign each individual in the group a specific task to be finished by the following week. After each meeting, a student has to send an email with a summary of the meeting and the assigned tasks to everyone involved. This email is very important to keep a record of your progress in the SDP. It works as a perfect evidence and record of who is doing the work and who is not for any dispute that might happen in the future.

1.4. Examination Committee and Mentor Assignment

Around week six of the term, the SDP committee is going to announce the examination committee that will examine you at the end of the term. Two faculty from the Electrical Engineering Department will act as the examination committee for both your SDP1 and SDP2.

Your technical mentor will also be assigned to your group.

1.5. Weekly work with the mentor

Once your technical mentor is assigned, you need to go see him/her and schedule a weekly meeting. You have to come to the meeting and show your

technical progress to the mentor. Your mentor should be involved in the following:

- The parts you need to purchase for your project and if cheaper solutions can be found.
- Understanding the datasheet of the purchased parts.
- Testing and operating the purchased parts

1.6. Ordering the parts

You need to plan the purchasing of SDP parts and components as early as you can to avoid long delays in shipping. All parts and components will be brought to you by the Central Labs, so you should not buy anything yourself.

Once you decide on the parts you need to purchase, you have to fill the respected form and get the green light from your mentor. Once you do that, you need the approval of your supervisor.

Each SDP group should fill the form with all the needed SDP parts and sign it by their supervisor.

The following are the steps to be followed:

- You have to first fill the form with all necessary information
- The form has to be signed by your supervisor
- The form has to be submitted in an excel format
- The form has to be submitted to your mentor by email, CCing your supervisor + SDP mates + SDP coordinator.
- The subject of your email should be “SDP1_# SDP Parts”
- The maximum amount **should not exceed AED 5000.**

The deadline to submit the form will be on the SDP Calendar. Any request without the proper link of the item is not accepted and it is recommended to put a local supplier/link in the request.

- Below are some examples which were already contacted by Central Lab for the reference of students:

- Amazon.ae
- Aliexpress.ae
- bluePCB <https://www.blue-pcb.com/>
- Besomi <https://besomi.com/>
- NoonOnline Shopping UAE | Fashion, Electronics, Beauty, Baby | noon
- Techmaze
- Desertcart.ae
- Farhan electronics

- Camed <https://cameduae.com/contact-v2/>
- Polular Electronics <https://www.popularelectronic.com/>

If the item is not available locally, the students has to consider a delay of around 2 to 3 months in the delivery (depending on the country of origin) so you need to plan ahead and order the item as soon as possible.

1.7. Preparing the SDP1 report

You have to start working on your report early on during the term. Train yourself to produce progress reports on weekly bases covering everything you do during the term. This will save you time at the end, you only need to reformat these progress reports and put them into one document.

A report template will be given to you with good samples from previous years. These act as a general guideline; at the end your supervisor will walk you through the process to produce a good report.

1.7.1. Using AI to write the report

Using AI tools such as ChatGPT to write parts of your SDP report is considered cheating. You are being assessed based on your ability to write a proper technical report. When you use ChatGPT, you are claiming something that you did not do yourself. So, it is considered a cheating.

Your SDP examiners are going to check for AI generated text using many open-source AI detectors available on the net. Any suspected cases will be investigated and students will receive zero if they used AI tools to write the report.

Examiners have the right to ask the SDP group to explain any suspicion of AI-generated text. Examiners might ask you to meet with them (before, during, or after the SDP official exam) to answer and clarify any suspicion of using AI tools. All examiners are paying very close attention to this issue so be careful this term. There will be zero-tolerance for any cheating case. You will receive zero on the SDP report, and you will be referred to a disciplinary committee. You will most probably fail the SDP.

1.7.2. Submission procedure and deadline of the report to the examination committee

The examination committee is not going to accept your report submission without the approval of your supervisor. So, you need to get the approval of your supervisor before submission.

The deadline of report submission will be given on the SDP calendar. The submission has to be by email. The plagiarism link on BB is to obtain the similarity report only.

The similarity report should not show more than 20%. This does not mean that you are allowed to copy 20% of the report. The 20% is put in place because of possible similarities of titles, references, technical words, etc. So, there will be no compromise when it comes to cheating in the report writing.

The report can be submitted by any member in the SDP group, multiple submission by more than one member of the same group should not impact the similarity score.

The report has to be submitted by email along with the SafeAssign Summary report to the Supervisor and the Examination Committee, putting the project mates in the CC, the subject of the email should be SDP2_N#: SDP report submission.

You should submit the following documents by email to the examination committee:

- All documents should be submitted in pdf format.
- The original proposal you submitted when you started SDP, the name should be: SDP1_N#_Proposal.
- The safe assign summery report showing the similarity level, the name should be: SDP1_N#_SafeAssign_Report.
- The SDP report (written following the provided template), the name should be: SDP1_N#_InitialReport.
- A snapshot of the supervisor report approval (by email) should be included as well.
- Send these documents by email to: the examination committee, your supervisor, the SDP coordinator, and the SDP group mates.

1.8. SDP1 Final Exam Presentation Instructions

The final SDP exams are usually in the 14th week of the term. The examination period will be given in the SDP calendar. The specific location and timeslot of your final exam presentation is going to be announced to you ahead of time.

The following are the examination rules and procedures:

- The exam is going to be on campus in the specified room announced to you.
- The SDP1 exam is 25 min, 15 min presentation, and 10 min questions by the examiners.
- Practice well, and abide by the scheduled exam time, if you take more time you will be stopped and marks will be deducted.
- Make sure that the SDP report is handy, examiners might ask you questions from your report.
- Send your presentations by email to the examiners and supervisor before the exam, and bring a print out to give to the examination committee in the exam.
- Enter the exam room 5 mins before your presentation time.
- Once you are done, leave the room to open the floor for the next exam.
- Bring your laptop with you, it has to have an HDMI connector so you can plug it to the overhead projector. I really advise you to also bring a second backup laptop in case of any problems.

1.9. Updating the report after modifications

The SDP examiners are going to send you comments and suggestions that you need to implement. You need to implement all these changes and show the updated report to your supervisor and get his/her final approval of the report. You have to also check the updated report using the safe assign link again after implementing all changes.

1.10. Submitting the final SDP1 documents

Once you update your final SDP1 report based on the examiners recommendations, you should put all your SDP1 material for the final

submission through Blackboard. Submit early, as soon as you finish to avoid uploading delays.

All files should be named according to the following name format:

"SDP1_N#_" where the N# is the SDP group number.

Compress the following documents into a single ZIP file and submit it through the "SDP Final Documents Submission link" provided on BB:

- SDP1_N#_InitialReport.pdf: this is the initial report you submitted to the examination committee before the exam.
- SDP1_N#_FinalReport.pdf: this is the final report updated based on the comments from the examination committee after the exam.
- SDP1_N#_ExaminersComments.pdf: compile all the comments from the examiners and put them in a single pdf file (take a snap shot of all comments and put them in one file).
- SDP1_N#_SafeAssignReport.pdf: this is the SafeAssign similarity report you obtained for the FinalReport version (use the same Plagiarism link to obtain the similarity report).
- SDP1_N#_Presentation.pptx: this is your power point SDP presentation.
- SDP1_N#_SupportingDocuments: this is a folder not a file, it contains everything else that you want to include in the submission (code, videos, pictures, datasets, etc.).

If the final ZIP file is > 500MB it might take some time to upload, there should be no limit on the file size. Try to upload very early in the morning so the traffic is minimal.

If any of the above points are not met, your SDP mark will be "Incomplete" until you fix all issues.

1.11. What are you expected to do by the end of SDP1

By the end of SDP1 students are expected to finish the following:

- Understand the problem you are trying to solve and the motivation behind it.
- Understand and define the scope of your proposed solution.
- Do a literature survey about the subject and understand the pros and cons of the alternative solutions. Compare your proposed solution to existing ones.

- Study and learn the needed technical skills about the subject. For example, if you need to use python in your work, then you have to study and learn how to program with python in SDP1. If you need to use machine learning, you have to study as well. By the end of SDP1, you have to learn all the needed skills in order to implement and execute your project.
- Finish the overall design of the proposed project. This initial design might change later during implementation.
- Decide, and purchase all hardware parts to be used in the SDP1. You might purchase more parts later but you have to buy the bulk in SDP1 to save shipping delays. You should consult with your project mentor when you decide on your project parts.
- Test and understand the datasheet, operation manual, and specs of all hardware parts. You should consult with your project mentor when you decide on your project parts.
- Submit a well written report.
- Present your work to the examination committee and address their questions and queries.
- Submit all required documents by the end of the SDP through BB.

1.12. Important Documents

1.12.1. SDP Calendar

The SDP calendar is a specific document for each term with important deadlines and submission dates.

1.12.2. Syllabus

You can find the course description and the mark distributions and other important information in the course syllabus

1.12.3. Forms

- Group Registration Form (excel sheet file): use this document to list the newly formed SDP group and the name of the supervisor
- SDP Proposal form (doc file): you will write the SDP proposal using this document
- SDP Purchasing Request form.

- Rubrics: you will be evaluated in the exam based on these rubrics. These rubrics are used to evaluate: SDP1 proposal, course work during the term, report, and presentation.
- Templates: SDP report template should be used when you write your report.

2. Senior Design Project II

In this section, explanations of the important points about SDP2 are detailed.

2.1. Weekly work with the supervisor

The weekly meetings with the supervisor should continue. The work in SDP2 is more demanding than SDP1. As in SDP1, meeting face-to-face is better for proper communication and understanding. You can meet online for exceptional situations only.

The supervisor should assign each individual in the group a specific task to be finished by the following week. After each meeting, a student has to send an email with a summary of the meeting and the assigned tasks to everyone involved. This email is very important to keep a record of your progress in the SDP. It works as a perfect evidence and record of who is doing the work and who is not for any dispute that might happen in the future.

2.2. Weekly work with the mentor

You need to continue to meet with your mentor on weekly bases, especially that SDP2 is about the hardware implementation to produce the target prototype. You have to meet and show your technical progress to the mentor. Your mentor should be involved in the following:

- Purchasing any additional parts that you might need.
- Testing and operating the purchased parts.
- Assembling the target prototype through putting together the sub-models before building the whole system

2.3. Ordering more parts

You might need to buy more parts that you overlooked during SDP1. All parts and components will be brought to you by the Central Labs, so you should not buy anything yourself. You have to fill the respected form and get the green light from your mentor. Once you do that, you need the approval of your supervisor. Each SDP group should fill the form with any needed SDP parts and sign it by their supervisor.

The following are the steps to be followed:

- You have to first fill the form with all necessary information
- The form has to be signed by your supervisor
- The form has to be submitted in an excel format

- The form has to be submitted to your mentor by email, CCing your supervisor + SDP mates + SDP coordinator.
- The subject of your email should be “SDP2_# SDP Parts”
- The maximum amount **should not exceed AED 5000**, including the already purchased parts in SDP1.

Any request without the proper link of the item is not accepted and it is **recommended to put a local supplier/link in the request.**

- Below are some examples which were already contacted by Central Lab for the reference of students:

- Amazon.ae
- Aliexpress.ae
- bluePCB <https://www.blue-pcb.com/>
- Besomi <https://besomi.com/>
- NoonOnline Shopping UAE | Fashion, Electronics, Beauty, Baby | noon
- Techmaze
- Desertcart.ae
- Farhan electronics
- Camed <https://cameduae.com/contact-v2/>
- Polular Electronics <https://www.popularelectronic.com/>

If the item is **not available locally**, the students has to consider a delay of around 2 to 3 months in the delivery (depending on the country of origin) so **you need to plan ahead and order the item as soon as possible.**

2.4. SDP2 Midterm Presentation

The SDP2 midterm presentation has to be scheduled by students during the University announced midterm period (consult the university academic calendar for that). Usually, the midterm period covers weeks 7-9 of the term. The students have to contact their supervisor and examiners (same examiners as SDP1) to schedule the SDP2 midterm.

Midterm Scheduling Instructions:

- Find an empty 30 minutes slot for the supervisor, and examiners.
- Fill the midterm form
- send the form in doc format by email to your supervisor, and examiners, (CCing your SDP group mates), asking for the approval of the Supervisor and Examiners. The approval can be by email, if so write "approved by email" in the signature place.

- Once approved, send the file to your SDP Coordinator in pdf format. The SDP coordinator will schedule the exam and let you know the exam room (if all rooms are busy, you might need to reschedule)
- Write the subject of the email: SDP2_N#: Midterm Exam Date.

The midterm exam can be scheduled any time within the midterm period.

What do you expect to show during the midterm:

- The midterm duration is 30 minutes.
- The presentation time should not exceed 15 minutes, and 15 minutes for Q&A by the examiners.

You should focus in your presentation on the following:

- the SDP tasks/work already done
- the remaining SDP tasks to be finished by the end of the term
- a short video demo showing the parts you finished so far
- actions and comments taken to address the examiners concerns given to you during the SDP1 final exam.

2.5. Working on the SDP2 report

You have to start working on your report early on during the term. Train yourself to produce progress reports on weekly bases covering everything you do during the term. This will save you time at the end, you only need to reformat these progress reports and put them into one document.

A report template will be given to you with good samples from previous years. These act as a general guideline; at the end your supervisor will walk you through the process to produce a good report.

The SDP2 report is going to include some parts of the SDP1 report. The report does not have to include all the details you had in SDP1. You have to consult with your supervisor to know what parts you are going to keep and what parts you are going to remove.

2.5.1. Using AI to write the report

Using AI tools such as ChatGPT to write parts of your SDP report is considered cheating. You are being assessed based on your ability to write a proper technical report. When you use ChatGPT, you are claiming something that you did not do yourself. So, it is considered a cheating.

Your SDP examiners are going to check for AI generated text using many open-source AI detectors available on the net. Any suspected cases will be investigated and students will receive zero if they used AI tools to write the report.

Examiners have the right to ask the SDP group to explain any suspicion of AI-generated text. Examiners might ask you to meet with them (before, during, or after the SDP official exam) to answer and clarify any suspicion of using AI tools. All examiners are paying very close attention to this issue so be careful this term. There will be zero-tolerance for any cheating case. You will receive zero on the SDP report, and you will be referred to a disciplinary committee. You will most probably fail the SDP.

If you used AI tools in SDP1 and you were not caught in SDP1 or you did not remove the AI generated text from your SDP1 portion, be careful, you are still responsible of what you submit, and you will be penalized again for using AI in writing the SDP2 report.

2.5.2. Submission procedure and deadline of the report to the examination committee

The examination committee is not going to accept your report submission without the approval of your supervisor. So, you need to get the approval of the supervisor before submission.

The deadline of report submission will be given on the SDP calendar. The submission has to be by email. The plagiarism link on BB is to obtain the similarity report only.

The similarity report should not show more than 20%. This does not mean that you are allowed to copy 20% of the report. The 20% is put in place because of possible similarities of titles, references, technical words, etc. So, there will be no compromise when it comes to cheating in the report writing.

Note that, safeassign will never compare your SDP2 to your SDP1, since you are the same group, you will never have similarity issue with you previously submitted report.

The report can be submitted by any member in the SDP group, multiple submission by more than one member of the same group should not impact the similarity score.

The report has to be submitted by email along with the SafeAssign Summary report to the Supervisor and the Examination Committee, putting the project

mates in the CC, the subject of the email should be SDP2_N#: SDP report submission.

You should submit the following documents by email to the examination committee:

- All documents should be submitted in pdf format.
- The original proposal you submitted when you started SDP, the name should be: SDP2_N#_Proposal.
- The safe assign summery report showing the similarity level, the name should be: SDP2_N#_SafeAssign_Report.
- The SDP report (written following the provided template), the name should be: SDP2_N#_InitialReport.
- A snapshot of the supervisor report approval (by email) should be included as well.
- Send these documents by email to: the examination committee, your supervisor, the SDP coordinator, and the SDP group mates.

2.6. Using the SDP room

You should make use of the SDP room in the labs. The room is an important space that you can use to build your prototype. You can use to store your parts to be used in the implementation. Your supervisor and mentor might visit you in that room to see your work.

2.7. SDP2 video demo and Poster submission:

SDP2 Students are required to submit the SDP2 poster and project video demo before the final SDP exams. The exact date will be given on the SDP calendar.

2.7.1. SDP2 demo

It is very important for the SDP2 to make a video demo of their SDP2 prototype. This demo is going to be used as a backup in case the SDP2 prototype failed in the last minute. The video has to show the full operation and explanation of the prototype. It has to show all features with background explanation of each feature. The video has to show the title of the project, student names and numbers and the supervisor's name.

The video will be marked based on showing the full operation of the prototype along with explaining what the prototype does, it has to show all parts with proper explanation. The video will be used also later in department and college competitions.

A specific link on BB will be given for you to submit the SDP2 video demo.

2.7.2. Submitting the SDP2 Poster

The SDP2 poster has to be prepared by students and submitted through a link provided on BB. The poster has to be submitted in two sizes: A1 and A3 sizes. You will be given templates for both sizes. You should not make major changes to the templates.

Follow the instructions below regarding the Poster Submission:

- make sure you use the updated logo in the poster.
- Submission deadline is going to be given on the SDP calendar.
- You should submit your poster in ppt format only (not pdf otherwise you will lose marks).
- You should submit your posters in two sizes: A1 and A3 using the given templates.
- Use the given templates to design your poster (You have to keep the orange-colored boxes, you can do minimal changes only).
- Putting the group team photos on the poster is optional.
- Putting the supervisor photo on the poster can be after his/her approval.
- There will be a competition to select the best poster, so make sure you put enough effort into it.

2.8. SDP2 Final Exam Instructions

The final SDP exams are usually in the 14th week of the term. The examination period will be given in the SDP calendar. The specific location and timeslot of your final exam presentation is going to be announced to you ahead of time.

The following are the examination rules and procedures:

- The exam is going to be on campus in the specified room announced to you.

- The SDP2 exam is 45 min, 25 min presentation, and 20 min questions by the examiners. This time does not include the video or live demo. The demo has to be done after the exam is done.
- Practice well, and abide by the scheduled exam time, if you take more time you will be stopped and marks will be deducted.
- Make sure that the SDP report is handy, examiners might ask you questions from your report.
- Send your presentations by email to the examiners and supervisor before the exam, and bring a print out to give to the examination committee in the exam.
- Enter the exam room 5 mins before your presentation time.
- Once you are done, leave the room to open the floor for the next exam.
- Bring your laptop with you, it has to have an HDMI connector so you can plug it to the overhead projector. I really advise you to also bring a second backup laptop in case of any problems.

Regarding the Project Demo:

- The project demo should be scheduled in agreement with the examiners at any time during the SDP Exam period.
- The scheduling is the responsibility of the students.

It is very important to make a demo video of the final prototype. This video should work as a backup in case the prototype failed during the demo time. You will be asked to upload the video to BB.

2.9. Final SDP documents submission

By the end of the SDP, students should submit all documents and prototype. The submission Deadline is going to be shown on the SDP calendar. Submit early, as soon as you finish the demo and update the report to avoid uploading delays.

All files should be named according to the following name format:

"SDP2_N#_" where the N# is the SDP number.

Compress the following SDP documents into a single ZIP file and submit using the "SDP Final Documents Submission Link" on BB:

- SDP2_N#_InitialReport.pdf: this is the initial report you submitted to the examination committee before the exam.
- SDP2_N#_FinalReport.pdf: this is the final report updated based on the comments from the examination committee after the exam.

- SDP2_N#_ExaminersComments.pdf: compile all the comments of the examiners and put them in a single pdf file.
- SDP2_N#_SafeAssignReport.pdf: this is the SafeAssign similarity report you obtained for the FinalReport version (use the same Plagiarism link to obtain the similarity report).
- SDP2_N#_Poster_A1.pptx and SDP2_N#_Poster_A3.pptx: these are the two versions of the SDP2 posters.
- SDP2_N#_Presentation.pptx: this is your power point SDP presentation.
- SDP2_N#_ProjectDemoVideo: this is your project video demonstrating your SDP2 project showing and running the prototype.
- SDP2_N#_OperationManual.pdf: this is a one/two pages document to show how to operate the prototype.
- SDP2_N#_SourceCodeFolder: this is a folder not a file, it should contain all the code you used in your project (e.g. raspberry pi code, c code, python code etc).
- SDP2_N#_SupportingDocuments: this is a folder not a file, it contains everything else that you want to include in the submission (datasets, pictures, extra videos, etc.).

If the final ZIP file is > 500MB it might take some time to upload, there should be no limit on the file size. Try to upload very early in the morning so the internet and BB traffic is minimal.

The prototype has to be submitted in person to your mentor or supervisor, communicate with your mentor and arrange the handover with him/her. If any of the above points are not met, your SDP mark will be "Incomplete" until you fix all issues.

2.10. What are you expected to do by the end of SDP2

By the end of SDP2 students are expected to finish the following:

- Understand the problem you are trying to solve and the motivation behind it.
- Understand and define the scope of your proposed solution.
- Understand the literature about the subject and the pros and cons of the alternative solutions. Compare your proposed solution to existing ones.
- Present an implementable final design of the prototype.

- Test and understand the datasheet, operation manual, and specs of all hardware parts. The examination committee will ask you about the sensors, modules, and hardware parts you used in your design.
- Submit a well written report.
- Finish a physical prototype and presented live to examiners.
- Produce and submit a video demo of the fully operational prototype.
- Produce and submit a well written poster in two sizes: A1 and A3.
- Present your work to the examination committee and address their questions and queries.
- Submit all required documents along with the physical prototype by the end of the SDP.

2.11. Important Documents

2.11.1. SDP Calendar

The SDP calendar is a specific document for each term with important deadlines and submission dates.

2.11.2. Syllabus

You can find the course description and the mark distributions and other important information in the course syllabus

2.11.3. Forms

- SDP2 Midterm form: use this document to schedule your SDP2 midterm.
- SDP Purchasing Request form.
- Rubrics: you will be evaluated in the exam based on these rubrics. These rubrics are used to evaluate: course work during the term, poster and demo video, report, and presentation.
- Poster A1 and A3 templates.
- Templates: SDP report template should be used when you write your report.